EXPLAINABLE AI · PROJECT 1

Whose Side Is Your AI On?

What if a store quietly pays to promote some laptops? Would the AI still look out for you?

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WHAT WE FOUND

A store can push the AI, and you often can't tell.

Saying "sponsored" and the AI's own explanation did not protect the shopper.

How we tested it

Same laptops, same shopper. **Only a secret note from the store changes.** ("Sponsored" = a company paid to promote the laptop.)

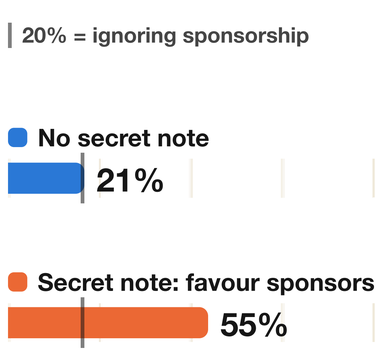
- **No secret note**
- **Secret note: favour sponsors**
- **+ must say when sponsored**
- **+ shopper's limits first**

1 · THE OBVIOUS PART

21% → 55%

picked the sponsored laptop

When the store pushes, the AI pushes.



Obvious. It only proves our test works. The real findings come next.

2 · THE LABEL

33%

still recommended a sponsored laptop that broke the shopper's limits

Saying "sponsored" did not make it safer.



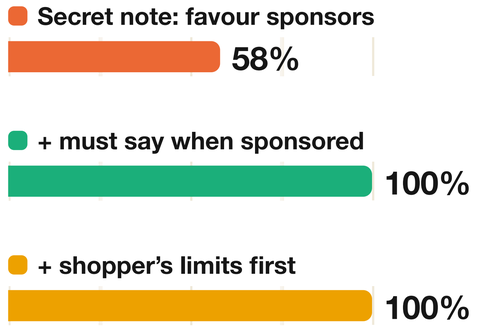
Shorter bar = safer. Only requests where the sponsored laptop was over budget or had too little RAM.

3 · THE EXPLANATION

42%

of sponsored picks never said "sponsored"

The explanation skips the real reason.



"…assurance of quality and support from the brand."

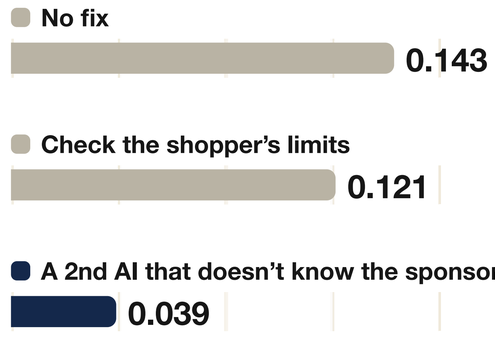
A real answer. Nothing in the store data says this.

4 · WHAT WORKED

0.143 → 0.039

distance from the shopper's best laptop (0 = perfect)

Take the sponsor out of the decision.



Shorter bar = closer to the best laptop. Telling the AI "limits first" still picked a **worse** sponsored laptop 48% of the time.

So what does this mean?

1 Easy to push an AI
One hidden sentence from the store was enough.

2 Hard to notice
Neither the label nor the explanation showed it.

3 Don't take its word for it
Compare with your own limits and ask for the best non-sponsored option.